

Impact: Medium Difficulty: Hard Misuse risk: Low

WHY IT WORKS

Physical movement is unconsciously read as an indicator of internal composure — fast, restless movement signals anxiety, while measured movement signals confidence and control. Your body communicates your state before you speak.

WHAT IT IS (AND ISN'T)

- Not freezing — a still baseline is relaxed and breathing, not a held pose.
- Not banning gesture — movement survives; it just has to be spent on purpose.
- It is an economy of motion in which every movement left is one that means something.

THE PAYOFF

How it lands: Watching them speak is calming — nothing about their body argues with their words.

Principle: An audience reads your body's steadiness as your mind's, and it reads the body first.

What you gain

- Attention on your words instead of your hands
- Gravity for serious moments that words alone cannot supply
- Nerves that stay private instead of broadcast
- Gestures that hit harder because they are rare
- A grounded feeling that works backwards on your own state

Why most people fail at it

- Adrenaline leaks straight into feet, hands, and pens.
- They mistake stillness for stiffness and lock every joint.
- They gesture continuously, so no gesture marks anything.
- They manage their movement so hard they lose track of their message.

CORE FORMULA

Still baseline -> Deliberate movement -> Gestures that reinforce the point

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Before your next important conversation or presentation, notice your default physical behaviour. Set a still baseline. Move only when you mean to.

BEST FOR

- Presentations and public speaking
- High-stakes face-to-face conversations
- Situations where physical composure matters
- Any context where nervousness tends to show in movement

METHOD, STEP BY STEP

1. Still — Set the still baseline

Before speaking, plant your feet, release your shoulders, and let your hands rest. This is the neutral your body returns to between every deliberate move.

Restless: (Rocking, pen-clicking, and weight-shifting through the whole opening.)

Settled: (Planted and relaxed before the first word — the room quietens to match.)

2. Move — Move only on purpose

When you move, make it one clean action — cross to the screen, lean in, turn to face someone — then return to the baseline. Movement that starts and finishes reads as intent; movement that dribbles reads as nerves.

Drifting: (Wandering the stage in loops that track your anxiety, not your argument.)

Deliberate: (Three steps to the chart, plant, make the point, return.)

3. Gesture — Spend gestures on the point

Save hand movement for the moments the content earns it, and match the gesture to the words. Two reinforcing gestures beat two hundred decorative ones.

Decorative: (Hands churning continuously, illustrating nothing.)

Reinforcing: (Hands still all meeting — then one open palm on 'the choice is yours'.)

FIELD TIP

Plant first, speak second.

The body settles faster than the mind — plant your feet, rest your hands, and composure follows rather than leads. Do it before the first word, because retro-fitting stillness mid-sentence looks like exactly what it is.

Situation: You are about to deliver an unpopular decision to the team.

Don't: (Shifting weight foot to foot, clicking the pen, starting before you have stopped moving.)

Do: (Feet planted, hands resting, one breath.) 'I have a decision to share, and I will explain it fully.'

PHRASE BANK

Grounding Phrases · Anchoring before you speak

- "Let me say this plainly."
- "I want to be direct about this."
- "The straightforward answer is..."
- "My view, simply: ..."
- "To be clear: ..."
- "The bottom line is..."

Recovery Phrases · When you notice excess movement

- "[Plant feet. Pause. Continue.]"
- "[Still hands. Look at the person. Finish the sentence.]"
- "[Slow the pace. Stop moving. Speak from here.]"

Spoken Anchors · Lines delivered from a planted position

- "I am going to stay right here for this part, because it matters."
- "Let me put everything down and give you the headline."
- "Before I move on, I want to let that point stand for a moment."
- "I will take the next section from just here."
- "Let me stop walking and say this plainly."
- "This is the slide I want us to sit with for a minute."

Stillness as Attention · Settling your body to give someone the floor

- "Let me put my phone away — you have my full attention."
- "I am in no hurry. Take whatever time you need."
- "I am going to sit back and just listen for a while."
- "Nothing about this needs rushing — go on."
- "I am not going anywhere. Start wherever feels right."
- "Let me close the laptop; this deserves better than half of me."

Reading the Room Back In · When stillness or fidgeting is misread

- "I know I have gone very still — that is me concentrating, not switching off."
- "My pacing was nerves, not impatience. Let me stand still and try that again."
- "If I looked restless just then, it was energy, not disinterest."
- "I realise I was talking to the whiteboard, not to you. Let me turn around and say it properly."

- "That stillness was not coldness — I wanted the words to carry the weight."
- "I fidget when I am thinking hard. Ignore the pen; hear the point."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Constant fidgeting, rocking, or pacing while speaking
Better: Standing still but tight.
Best: Relaxed stillness as the default. Deliberate movement to punctuate key points.
2. Weak: Large gestures that do not match the verbal content
Better: Smaller gestures.
Best: Gestures that precisely reinforce what is being said. No more.
3. Weak: Shrinking posture — hunched, small, tight
Better: Upright posture.
Best: Natural upright alignment with relaxed shoulders. No performance, no contraction.

DECISION TREE

If You notice you are fidgeting or moving excessively

Plant your feet or rest your hands. Still baseline. Then continue.

If You need to move to make a point

Move once, deliberately, to make the point. Return to the baseline.

If Your stillness is reading as rigid or cold

Use intentional, warm movement — a lean forward, a gesture. Once. Then return.

If You are presenting and moving constantly around the room

Move to a spot. Plant. Finish the point. Then move again if needed.

SCENARIOS

Presenting to a large audience

Move intentionally to different positions to mark sections. Still between moves. — "[Move to centre. Pause. Open statement. Move right for first main point.]"

High-stakes conversation across a table

Still posture. Lean in slightly for emphasis. Return to baseline. — "[Lean in] This is the key point. [Sit back]"

Delivering difficult news

Very still. Slow. No nervous movement. Let the words carry the weight. — "[Plant. Still. Speak slowly and directly.]"

Nervousness causing excessive movement

Name the ground under your feet. Plant. Breathe. Begin. — "[Ground. Breathe. Begin.]"

WORKED EXAMPLE

Without the technique

(You walk into the presentation room quickly, shuffle papers, adjust your position repeatedly, fidget while speaking)
(Audience perceives nervousness, which lowers their confidence in your message)

With the technique

(You walk in at a steady pace, set materials down deliberately, pause before beginning)
(Audience perceives composure — your message lands with more authority before you say a word)

COMMON MISTAKES

Stillness locked into rigidity

Sounds like: (Shoulders up, joints locked, barely breathing)

Better: Still means settled — feet planted, shoulders down, breath moving.

Pacing that tracks anxiety, not argument

Sounds like: (Laps of the stage with no relationship to the content)

Better: Move to mark a new section, plant, and stay until the next one.

Constant gesturing that flattens every point

Sounds like: (Hands illustrating every syllable)

Better: Rest the hands by default so the one gesture that matters still has somewhere to go.

Fidgeting with props

Sounds like: (Clicking the pen, spinning the phone, straightening papers mid-sentence)

Better: Empty your hands before you start — a prop in hand is a fidget waiting to happen.

Managing the body so hard the message suffers

Sounds like: Wooden delivery while you audit your own limbs

Better: Set the baseline once at the start, then give your attention back to the words.

READING THE ROOM

Signs it is working

- Your physical presence matches the gravity of what you are saying.
- Nervousness is not leaking into visible movement.
- People focus on your words rather than your body.
- You feel more grounded in your body during difficult conversations.

Signs to adjust

- Stillness has gone so far it looks rigid or cold.
- Deliberate movement looks performed rather than natural.
- You are focusing so much on movement that your content suffers.
- Gestures are distracting rather than reinforcing.

WHEN NOT TO USE

- In casual, high-energy social settings where measured movement reads as stiff or unnatural.
- When genuine urgency requires rapid physical movement.
- When your natural movement style is already composed — over-engineering it creates self-consciousness.

RECOVERY LINES

Best line: 'I will put the pen down; it was doing my nerves out loud.'

- "Let me stand still for a second — I was pacing, and it was not helping either of us."
- "I will put the pen down; it was doing my nerves out loud."
- "I have been talking to the screen. Let me turn around and say this to you."
- "That stillness was concentration, not distance — I am fully with you."
- "Let me plant my feet and give you the short version properly."
- "My hands were saying more than my words there. Here is the point, plainly."

TECHNIQUE CHAINS

Presentation chain

Enter steadily -> plant -> open from stillness -> move once per section

(Walk in at a measured pace. Set materials down. Plant.)

Thank you for the time — I have three points and a recommendation.

(Three steps left, plant.) The first point is cost.

(Return to centre for the close.) The recommendation is simple.

Difficult news chain

Sit still -> slow the pace -> let the words carry the weight -> hold the baseline through their reaction

(Seated, settled, hands resting.)

I have news about the project, and it is not what we hoped.

The funding has been pulled. I want to talk about what happens next.
(Still and present while they take it in.)

RELATED TECHNIQUES

TC028 — Warm Vocal Baseline

Warm Vocal Baseline is the same principle in the voice — a settled register and a settled body make one coherent signal.

TC029 — Strategic Silence

Strategic Silence pairs naturally with stillness — a pause held in a still body reads as command, not blankness.

TC008 — No-Overexplaining Discipline

No-Overexplaining Discipline is the verbal form of this economy — stop moving when the point is made, stop talking when the point is made.

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Observe your baseline

In one conversation or meeting, notice your physical behaviour. What do you do by default?

Day 2 — Set a still baseline

In one meeting, consciously hold a still posture as your default for the full duration.

Day 3 — Deliberate movement

Move once during a presentation or conversation — intentionally, to reinforce a point. Then return to the baseline.

Day 4 — Grounding under pressure

The next time you feel nervous in a conversation, plant your feet before speaking.

Day 5 — Gesture once

Make one deliberate hand gesture that reinforces your main point. Use it once.

Day 6 — Presentation practice

Present a short piece of content while consciously managing your movement.

Day 7 — Calibration

Did others notice a change? Did you feel more grounded? Did any stillness read as cold?

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I set a still baseline before starting?
- Did I move deliberately — not reflexively or nervously?
- Were my gestures reinforcing the content rather than distracting from it?
- Did I avoid fidgeting, pacing, or rocking?
- Did I return to the baseline after deliberate movement?
- Did my physical presence match the gravity of what I was saying?
- Did I feel grounded rather than rigid?